

task MASTER

✱ **Abhyanand, 53**

Project Giving underprivileged a chance to get into IITs

Can-do Icon Nobel laureate Richard P. Feynman, for he saw physics as an integrated science

Nearly **2.4 lakh** candidates appeared for IIT-JEE in 2007 but only **7,200** cleared the exams



"Since then, I started investing time in their studies. Years later, when both my children qualified for the IITs and left for their respective institutes, I felt that I should never lose my 'inner teacher'—someone who had grown as strong as the part of me that was a cop." The B.Sc physics topper from Patna Science College, however, needed to find an outlet. After a few meetings with mathematician and teacher Anand Kumar, who was familiar with the struggles of deprived students, the concept of "Super 30" was born and the duo started the coaching programme in 2002.

The first batch of 30 deserving students—many of whom were children of marginal farmers studying in panchayat schools—was picked after extensively screening the shortlisted students. They

were brought to Patna and provided accommodation, food and gruelling coaching for seven months—all for free. Even today, the students of the programme don't have to pay for anything. His friend Kumar takes care of the expenses. The success of the programme was evident with 18 of the 30 students clearing the entrance exam in 2003.

The Super 30 programme was an eye-opener for everyone who thought that only students who could afford expensive IIT coaching could clear the tough entrance examination. According to Abhyanand, it is the difference in the method of teaching that is responsible for the Super 30's success. Says Ritesh Ranjan, a student of the programme, "The Super 30 teachers leave nothing to chance. They cover every topic

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A teacher is someone who never gives the right answer, but always ask the right questions.

ABHYANAND, Additional DGP, Bihar

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SUPER TEACHER:
Abhyanand with students



and leave nothing untouched. They also help us develop confidence in our abilities." Last year, thanks to the school's burgeoning reputation, around 10,000 students from all over the country turned up for the entrance test. The coaching programme may have run out of a thatched hut with creaking benches under a hot tin roof, but a question from a teacher will often see all 30 hands shooting skywards.

The next batch of Super 30 classes is set to begin in September, but without Abhyanand. He has "moved on and will now expand the concept of Super 30 and pick underprivileged Muslim students and train them for competitive exams". The IAS officer has some time till then for the Class V students—and for the teacher in him to grow as well. And Abhyanand, once again turns to the young faces, transfixed in silence as he paces in front of a blackboard to explain how 10-digit multiplication problems can be solved without putting pen to paper. Abhyanand and his students embody the age-old *guru-shishya* tradition, where the two are bound together by an unusual intellect and a common drive. ■